A pebble is effectively thrown into the water when the youngster is introduced to a tennis coach named Danny Sullivan, a former professional player who just happens to be living in the same town. The boy's parents book and pay for two lessons per week and, completely unseen, a process is started.

'You need to hit 1 000 balls every day,' the coach tells the youngster, leaving him in no doubt that he will only realise his full potential if he is prepared to work hard and make sacrifices.

'You need to prepare correctly for every practice and every match,' he says, creating special routines for packing kit and equipment, and always remembering to bring a plastic bottle filled with water.

'You need to write brief notes for yourself, summarising your game plan, which you can read as you change ends between games,' the coach says, and so the seeds of lifelong habits are sown.

Danny Sullivan taught me basic lessons on the tennis court before my seventh birthday, and these basic lessons have remained with me ever since and become the foundations of my cricket career: hard work is non-negotiable, prepare properly for every practice and match, and create and stick to the game plan.

There is no doubt in my mind. The performances that appear to have pleased crowds in cricket grounds around South Africa, throughout India and elsewhere, originate from a tennis court in Warmbaths.

In fact, my coach seemed to have some idea of what could just possibly lie ahead for me. After another energetic training session, he told my parents: 'Well, this boy is certainly different – he'll either grow up to play for South Africa in one sport or another … or he's going to end up in prison.'

Danny moved to Stellenbosch, embarking upon a distinguished coaching career that would include spells with Christo van Rensburg, Marcos Ondruska and Ivan Lendl, but he left me in the capable hands of an ideal replacement: his father, Derek Sullivan – Oom Derek, as I called him.